PRODUCT SPEC · REVIEW COPY · 10 NOV 2026

Holdfast

Name your price. Your agent holds it.

Shoppers back any product with a real PayPal hold. Brands clear their overstock privately into money that's already waiting — without ever posting a lower public price.

MONEY PATH: GO | SANDBOX TESTS PASSED 10 NOV | DEADLINE 12 NOV · 12:00 PST

01 The problem, in plain words

Brands

Every quarter brands are stuck with last season's stock. Their choices are bad: sell it to a liquidator for pennies (our example: **$38 a unit** for $279 headphones), or slash the price in public — which upsets their retailers and teaches customers to wait for sales.

Shoppers

"I'd buy it at $229" has nowhere to go. Wishlists and price alerts don't commit anyone to anything, so brands ignore them.

Why it failed before — and why now is different

"Name your own price" sites died because bids were free, so sellers didn't trust them. Holdfast fixes that:

- **A PayPal hold makes every bid real.** The money is reserved on the shopper's account, but not charged.
- **An AI agent does the work** — finds the exact product, suggests a price, and protects the shopper.
- **The brand sees real committed demand** before it sells a single unit.

Agents negotiate by bidding. Code clears. PayPal settles.

02 Who's involved

WHO	WHAT THEY DO
Shopper	Names a price, approves one PayPal hold, then either wins or gets the money released.

Shopper's agent	An AI assistant that finds the exact product, suggests a fair bid, places or adjusts it within limits the shopper set — and cancels it if any store sells cheaper.
Outside agents	Other AI assistants (e.g. Claude Desktop) can bid through our open connection (MCP), using their owner's PayPal.
Brand manager	Lists overstock, watches the private demand, and presses **Clear**.
Brand's agent	Recommends how many to sell, and during live rounds tells bidders the real cutoff so they can raise. It can only talk — it can never sell or move money.
Price watcher	Works for the shopper: if a store drops below their bid, it releases the hold — only if the shopper left "release if cheaper elsewhere" on (the default).
Clearing engine	Simple, fixed rules that decide who wins. Each winner pays their own bid.
Settlement	Background jobs that charge the winners, release everyone else, and pay the brand.
PayPal	Holds, charges, releases and pays out the money.

The golden rule: AI chooses *what to bid*. Plain code decides *who wins and what is charged*. Only our server ever touches PayPal.

03 A sale, start to finish

Example: the brand **Aurel Audio** has 300 pairs of **Aurel A7 Wireless headphones** (normally $279). It won't sell below $199. A liquidator offered $38 each. Bidding runs 48 hours, then up to 6 hours of live rounds.

01 **The shopper bids.** "I'd buy these at $229." The agent confirms it's the exact product, shows the cheapest store price ($279), and the shopper approves once with PayPal. **$229 is held, not charged.**

02 **The agent keeps watch.** It watches 25 stores. If any sells the same new headphones for less, it releases the hold and sends the link — unless the shopper switched that off because they want this seller anyway.

03 **The brand sees the demand.** A private dashboard shows "$61,240 already held at $219 or more", a demand curve, and how much it would earn versus the liquidator.

04 **Live rounds.** The brand's agent tells everyone below the cutoff the real number: "The cutoff for 240 units is $219. Raise to stay in?" Their agents raise once, within each shopper's limit — agents negotiating with agents.

05 **The brand clears.** It sells 240 units. The 240 highest bids win, and **each winner pays exactly their own bid** — never more than they approved. The other 46 holds are released.

06 **Money moves.** Each winner is charged their bid. If a card is declined, the next bidder in line gets that unit at their own bid (up to 3 tries per unit).

07 **The brand gets paid** through PayPal, minus our 9% fee, and every order gets shipment tracking.

08 **The shopper hears:** "You won at your bid of $229." with a delivery timeline. Everyone else: "Released, never charged."

SOLD	BRAND EARNS	AFTER 9% FEE	RELEASED
240	$54,240	$49,358	46
avg $226, lowest $219	vs $11,400 liquidation	paid to brand	holds, never charged

ORDER STATUS — SHOWN AS A TIMELINE EVERYWHERE

HOLD PLACED	PRICE WATCH · NOW	LIVE ROUNDS	CLEARED	CHARGED	BRAND PAID	SHIPPED

04 What we're building

MUST needed for the demo NICE if time allows LATER described only

FEATURE	PRIORITY	IN ONE LINE
Brand sign-up	MUST	Log in with PayPal, confirm the brand is real, set where payouts go.
Create a listing	MUST	Pick the exact product, set quantity, minimum price and window.
Offer page + held bid	MUST	A shareable page where shoppers enter a price and approve the hold.
Shopper's agent chat	MUST	Say what you want in plain words; the agent finds it and bids.
Price watcher	MUST	Cheaper elsewhere? The hold is released automatically.
Open agent connection (MCP)	MUST	Lets Claude Desktop and other assistants bid.
Brand dashboard (the star)	MUST	Live bids table, demand curve, "what if" slider, Clear button, timeline.
Clearing engine	MUST	Fixed rules; top bids win; each pays their own bid.
Live rounds	MUST	The brand's agent shares the real cutoff; shoppers' agents raise. The demo's big moment.
Settlement	MUST	Charge winners, release losers, replace declined cards, retry safely.
Payouts, fee, tracking	MUST	Pay the brand minus 9%; attach shipping to each order.
Audit trail	MUST	A permanent record of every money movement.
Security & many users at once	MUST	Each brand sees only its own data; no double charges under load.
Demo data	MUST	~285 simulated bidders, always clearly marked "SIM".
Shopper limits + auto re-bid	NICE	Max price and total budget; the agent re-bids in later sales.
Brand advisor agent	NICE	"Sell 240 — here's why."
Notifications	NICE	Held, released, nudge, won, shipped — email, push, in-app.
Landing page	NICE	The public website — being designed now.
"Make an offer" button for brand sites	LATER	Brands embed bidding on their own store.

05 The screens

SHOPPERS	BRANDS	AGENTS & PLATFORM
• Landing page	• Sign-in & verification	• Connect your AI (MCP)
• Offer page & PayPal approval	• Overview	• Agent activity
• My bids	• Create listing	• Admin audit log
• Bid detail with timeline	• **Listing dashboard**	• Error & edge states
• Agent chat	• Clear confirmation	• Notification set
• My limits	• Live settlement	
• "Price dropped — released"	• Payouts & reports	
• "Raise to stay in?"	• Share links, settings	
• Won & tracking	• Mobile alert & approve	

Web first; mobile works in the browser (no app store app).

06 How the winner is decided

1. Only live bids at or above the brand's minimum price count.
2. Highest bid first. On a tie, whoever bid earlier wins.
3. The top *N* win, where *N* is how many the brand sells.
4. **Each winner pays exactly their own final bid.** Nobody ever pays more than they approved.
5. Everyone else is released. If a winner's card fails, the next in line gets that unit at their own bid — up to 3 tries, then it stays unsold.
6. **Timing:** 48 h of bidding, up to 6 h of live rounds, up to 6 h to clear. PayPal only guarantees card holds for 3 days, so the system refuses to clear if any hold is older than 66 h.

The dashboard's "what if" slider uses the exact same rules, so what the brand previews is exactly what happens.

07 Quality promises

Money is safe

No double charges, even if something retries. Raising places the new hold before releasing the old one; the old one doesn't count against your limit, and if the new hold fails your old bid stands. Your bank may show a released hold as pending for a few days — we say so. Leftover holds are cleaned up nightly.

Many users at once

Bids arriving while a sale clears are politely refused. Spending limits are checked safely. Duplicate messages are ignored.

Privacy

Brands see only their own sales. The minimum price is never shown to shoppers or agents. Outside agents see only anonymous price ranges.

Agents stay in their lane

Agents must ask before moving money unless the shopper's limits allow it. The brand's agent can only send truthful nudges — never sell. Outside agents are rate-limited.

Honest

"Held, not charged" wording. Simulated bidders always marked SIM. The README says exactly what's real.

Fast & traceable

A 300-bid sale clears in under 2 seconds; the dashboard updates live; every money movement is permanently logged.

08 Under the hood (short version)

PART	WHAT WE USE
Server & database	Node + TypeScript on Render, Postgres
Background jobs	Render Workflows — one job per bid, with safe retries
Website & dashboard	React; AG Grid & AG Charts for the dashboard; Bryntum Gantt for timelines
AI	Claude, with tools; MCP for outside agents
Payments	PayPal: holds, charges, releases, saved cards, payouts, tracking
Product & prices	Channel3 — exact product match across 25k stores, price-drop alerts
Build helper	APIMatic's PayPal plugin, credited in the README

SPONSOR TOOLS IN PLAY

PAYPAL AG GRID BRYNTUM CHANNEL3 RENDER APIMATIC

09 Look & feel

Based on the **Acne** example from our moodboard: clean white pages framed by thin guide lines, square corners, **Geist** for text, **Geist Mono in capitals** for buttons and labels, near-black text, and **orange** for the main action.

The homepage hero is a muted pixel-art painting of a quiet lakeside warehouse with crates of waiting stock and a cargo boat — with a floating command box: *"Hold $229 for Aurel A7 headphones if no store goes under $249"* → HOLD ↵

Done: homepage hero, "How it works" section. **Process:** agree each screen's content first, then design it, one at a time; animation added after approval. Figma file "PayPal-Hack26", page "Holdfast — v3".

10 How we make money

- **9% success fee** on every sale — enough to cover PayPal's fees with margin.
- **Demand data** for brands: what people will really pay, backed by real money.
- **Referral income** when the agent sends a shopper to a cheaper store.

Where it grows: end-of-season electronics and outdoor gear → all overstock and returns → pre-orders before a product is even made → a neutral marketplace where AI shopping agents place committed orders.

11 What we'll be upfront about

- In the test version, **we sell on the brand's behalf** and pay them out. The real version would use PayPal's marketplace setup, which needs PayPal's approval.
- Most demo bidders are simulated and marked SIM; the bids we place live are real PayPal test holds.
- The whole sale fits in about 60 hours, because PayPal only guarantees card holds for 3 days.
- If the live price-drop feed isn't ready, we'll replay a recorded one and say so.

12 Still to do

ITEM	STATUS
Test the charge/release jobs on Render (local test passed)	To do
Test live price-drop alerts from Channel3	To do · backup: recorded replay
Check PayPal marketplace fees	30-min check, README note only
Set up Channel3 key and Render account	To do
Rename "Standing Orders" → "Holdfast" across our docs	After this review
Pick our second hackathon entry	Not decided
Replace the PayPal test password shared in chat	After the hackathon

13 We're done when...

- ☐ A brand lists a product and real shoppers place real PayPal test holds.
- ☐ Claude Desktop places a bid and it pops up live on the brand dashboard.
- ☐ A price drop releases a bid automatically.
- ☐ Live rounds: agents raise after a nudge from the brand's agent.
- ☐ Clear charges each winner their own bid, releases the rest, and replaces a declined card.
- ☐ The brand receives its payout.
- ☐ Every money movement is logged; simulated bidders are always labelled.
- ☐ It's live on Render, with an honest README, an open-source licence, and a demo video under 3 minutes.